



ALIPR

What is it?

ALIPR stands for Automatic Linguistic Indexing of Pictures—Real time. It is a software that names pictures. Given an image, ALIPR can automatically give an appropriate name to it. The vocabulary is currently limited to 330 words.

Who is behind the software?

It has been developed at Penn State University by Professors Jia Li and James Z Wang.

Why is this important?

Because it is a major advancement in the automation of tagging pictures. ALIPR's success is due in part to its vast database of colour, texture, and images.

Where will it be used?

Wherever loads of pictures are handled on a regular basis, and people don't have the time to tag them all—such as, for example, in scientists' and researchers' work.

When can one start using ALIPR?

ALIPR is currently waiting to be patented. For now it's free, and can be used by anybody. Just head to www.alipr.com. Give it a picture, and ALIPR will make 15 suggestions. You can upload an image and "alipr it." To help ALIPR learn, you can tick-mark correct suggestions, add your own tags, and make your image searchable!

How successful is it?

For a picture of two men playing polo, five of the names suggested were "animal," "sport," "people," "horse," and "polo." This picture can be found at www.alipr.com/about.html. Recently, ALIPR was tested on 5,411 images on Flickr. For half the images, the first word ALIPR generated figured in the users' tags!

is mostly due to the hype about its cutting-edge technology, including the Cell processor—the "supercomputer on a chip" (you can read about it in *Digit* November 2006)—and the Blu-Ray DVD drive. However, there's another important factor that contributed to the disappearance—only 400,000 units were shipped to the US, leaving a huge vacuum in gamers' hearts for Christmas. Sony needs the PS3 to sell spectacularly to counter the effect of the year's battery recalls, and speculation abounds that if they aren't able to fill this distribution gap soon, customers might just wander into the open arms of the Xbox 360 or the also newly-launched Nintendo Wii.

Prices for the PS3 start at \$500 (Rs 23,500) and go up to \$600 (Rs 28,200), making it considerably more expensive than the Xbox 360, and nearly double the price of the Wii. Still, Sony doesn't seem to be worried about the price, what with all the "future-proof" technology it's giving gamers in its console.

RED HAT BEWARE

Oracle And Unbreakable Linux

Rumours of this have been floating around for a few months now—Oracle has finally hit at rival Red Hat with their own Linux support programme called Oracle Unbreakable Linux. At the annual Oracle User Conference, CEO Larry Ellison announced their intentions of providing enterprise-level support for Linux along the same lines that they do for their database and application server suites.

Red Hat, Ellison pointed out, only gives support for the latest version of its distributions, so if you have a problem with an older

version, you need to invest in a product upgrade. Unbreakable, on the other hand, is a programme that will provide bug fixes and support for all releases of Linux—past, present and future.

Is the already fragmented Linux market headed for another fork in the road? Oracle's Chief Corporate Architect, Edward Screven, insists not. Unbreakable will be compatible with Red Hat Linux, thus making it easier for Oracle to woo Red Hat's existing customers. The service will even come at a lower price—\$99 per year per PC, with a special 50 percent discount if you sign up before January 31, 2007.

With no better way to make money off Linux than support, this is sure to spark of a very entertaining rivalry—something we've come to count on Larry Ellison for.

FINALLY

The PIC Is Dead

Don't know what AMD's PIC is? Neither do many people the world over, which is why this 2004

project has finally been canned by the chip manufacturer. The Personal Internet Communicator was supposed to be the ultimate low-cost PC for developing nations like India, but has gone the way of other such flops as the Simputer.

So little was the interest in the device that when AMD gave away one to every attendee at the World Congress on Information Technology in May, many PICs lay unclaimed days after the show. To get an eyeful of all the problems with the PIC, pick up your copy of *Digit*, June 2006, but the gist of the matter is that it offered too little to justify its \$185 price tag.

Even as India snubs Nicholas Negroponte and the One Laptop per Child (OLPC) project, the mission to provide emerging markets with affordable computing doesn't seem to slow down. We don't delude ourselves into believing that this is all philanthropy—clearly they're trying to grab a bite out of a much larger audience than the one that can afford more expensive PCs—but really, do the poor and hungry need computers? ■

